Cuba, and he felt confident enough to go on the attack. He accused Kennedy of having declared the blockade “out of hatred for the Cuban people and its government, but also because of considerations of the election campaign in the United States.” He also declared the blockade unlawful. “The Soviet Government,” read the letter, “considers that the violation of the freedom to use international waters and international air space is an act of aggression which pushes mankind toward the abyss of a world nuclear-missile war.” Refusing to order his captains to turn back, Khrushchev threatened resistance and retaliation: “We will … be forced on our part to take the measures we consider necessary and adequate in order to protect our rights. We have everything necessary to do so.”[9]

The letter was approved by the Presidium of the Central Committee, which met that day to discuss the evolving Cuban situation. But Khrushchev clearly did not consider the official response to Kennedy strong enough. He decided to send the president a personal letter as well. His courier was supposed to be Georgii Bolshakov, through whom in September he had passed a verbal message to Kennedy: “We repeat again that the Soviet Union is delivering only defensive weapons to Cuba.” He promised to do nothing to complicate Kennedy’s situation in the run-up to the congressional elections in November. It was the violation of the promise delivered by Bolshakov that upset Kennedy so much. Now Khrushchev wanted Bolshakov to deliver another message to Kennedy. Since it was extremely long, it could not be memorized and took the form of a letter.[10]

Khrushchev was clearly in a bellicose mood when he dictated his response to Kennedy’s demand to stop the ships. “You cannot fail to remember that both Hitler and Napoleon used such language in their day when speaking with small countries,” asserted Khrushchev. “Do you really think even now that the USA is made of one dough and countries that you threaten another?” asked Khrushchev rhetorically, continuing his attack. In order to muddy the waters, Khrushchev took full advantage of Kennedy’s references to offensive weapons rather than nuclear ones in his letters and pronouncements. On the one hand the Soviet leader denied the presence of Soviet nuclear weapons in Cuba on the grounds that they were not offensive, while on the other he implied that such weapons were there and asserted that they were under Soviet control.